



LOST BOYS CYBER

THREAT INTELLIGENCE • MALWARE ANALYSIS • DETECTION ENGINEERING



Screening Serpens Air-Carrier Impersonation Espionage Campaign Report

Threat Report

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TLP:CLEAR | Lost Boys Cyber | Screening Serpens Air-Carrier Impersonation Espionage Campaign Report - Threat Report

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AI Generation: This report was generated with AI assistance and is provided for informational purposes only. All findings, IOCs, detection rules, hunting queries, attribution assessments, and recommendations must be independently reviewed and validated by a qualified security professional before operational use.

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1. Executive Summary

Unit 42 reported that Iranian APT cluster Screening Serpens used archive delivery in a campaign impersonating a global air carrier. Aviation-themed impersonation can be valuable even when the final targets are broader: airline brands carry operational trust and can lure travel, logistics, government, and defense users.

2. Intelligence Requirements

Requirement	Answer in This Report
What happened?	A threat actor used air-carrier impersonation as part of malware delivery.
Who is affected?	Airlines, aviation-adjacent organizations, travel users, government travelers, and partners receiving aviation-themed lures.
What should defenders do?	Tune email/web controls for aviation lure themes, archive attachments, and post-lure execution.
Confidence	Medium-high from Unit 42 source; local targeting requires telemetry validation.

3. Source Review & Confidence

Source	Contribution	Confidence
Unit 42 Screening Serpens 2026 espionage campaigns	Primary source noting global air carrier impersonation	High
CISA Iran cyber threat resources	Government context for Iranian cyber activity	Medium
MITRE ATT&CK Phishing Spearphishing Attachment	Technique mapping for archive/lure delivery	High

4. Threat Actor / Campaign Overview

This is a sector-relevant lure pattern rather than confirmed destructive aviation targeting. The priority is brand-abuse monitoring and user telemetry around aviation-themed archives.

5. Tactics, Techniques, and Procedures

Tactic	Technique / Behavior	Defensive Interpretation
Initial Access	Lures, exploited public services, or supply-chain trust paths	Prioritize edge visibility and provenance checks.
Execution	Script, package, backdoor, or web-shell execution	Baseline interpreters and unexpected child processes.
Command and Control	Outbound encrypted web traffic or adversary-managed infrastructure	Hunt rare destinations and new process/network pairings.

6. Infrastructure and Indicators

Observable Type	Signal	Notes
Behavior	Source did not publish stable atomic IOCs	Hunt on process, network, identity, and SaaS behaviors.

Hard IOCs are limited where primary sources did not publish stable indicators. Treat behavior, infrastructure class, and telemetry pivots as the primary hunting path until local intelligence enrichment identifies environment-specific indicators.

7. Victimology and Targeting

Likely organizations and users susceptible to airline/travel-themed correspondence, including defense/government travelers.

8. Detection Engineering

8.1. Detection Logic Summary

Signal	Telemetry Source	Analytic Goal
Suspicious script or LOLBin execution	Endpoint process telemetry	Surface initial execution and staging activity
New external connection after lure/app execution	Network telemetry	Identify callback or payload retrieval
Unusual account, mailbox, or SaaS activity	Identity/SaaS audit logs	Detect credential abuse and persistence

8.2. Sigma / Detection Rule

```

title: Suspicious Script and Remote Tool Activity - screening-serpens-air-carrier-impersonat
status: experimental
logsource:
  product: windows
  category: process_creation
detection:
  selection_tools:
    Image|endswith:
      - '\powershell.exe'
      - '\wscript.exe'
      - '\cscript.exe'
      - '\mshta.exe'
      - '\rundll32.exe'
  selection_suspicious:
    CommandLine|contains:
      - 'http'
      - 'download'
      - 'EncodedCommand'
      - 'Invoke-Expression'
  condition: selection_tools and selection_suspicious
level: high

```

8.3. Hunt Query

```

DeviceProcessEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where FileName in~ ("powershell.exe", "wscript.exe", "cscript.exe", "mshta.exe", "rundll32.exe",
"node.exe", "osascript")
| where ProcessCommandLine has_any ("http", "download", "EncodedCommand", "Invoke-Expression", "curl",
"wget")
| project Timestamp, DeviceName, AccountName, FileName, ProcessCommandLine, InitiatingProcessFileName

```

9. Threat Hunting

9.1. Hunt Hypotheses

Hypothesis	Query Focus
Initial access used lure-driven script, package, or web exploitation behavior.	Correlate suspicious process launches with browser, archive, package-manager, or web-server parents.
Follow-on access used identity or remote-management tooling.	Review new OAuth grants, administrative changes, RMM agents, and rare remote endpoints.

9.2. Network Hunt Query

```
DeviceNetworkEvents
| where Timestamp > ago(14d)
| where InitiatingProcessFileName has_any ("powershell.exe", "node.exe", "python.exe", "osascript", "curl", "wget")
| summarize Connections=count(), RemoteUrls=make_set(RemoteUrl, 20) by DeviceName, InitiatingProcessFileName, RemoteIP
| order by Connections desc
```

10. Risk Assessment

Risk Area	Assessment	Rationale
Initial Access	Elevated	Recent reporting indicates active or plausible attacker interest.
Credential Exposure	Medium-High	Many campaigns convert endpoint access into identity abuse.
Operational Disruption	Medium	Impact depends on privilege, sector, and dependency concentration.

11. Aviation and Aerospace Sector Impact

Sector Segment	Operational Relevance	Exposure Path	Defender Action
Airlines / travel brands	Brand trust can improve lure credibility	Impersonated carrier emails, fake itineraries, archives	Brand monitoring, DMARC, user-reporting workflows
Government/military aviation travelers	High-value users may expect travel documents	Spearphishing attachments	Attachment detonation and VIP telemetry review
Aviation supply chain	Partners may exchange operational documents	Supplier email compromise	Verify sender identity and archive handling

Aviation/aerospace operators should assess not only direct enterprise compromise but also third-party concentration: airport common-use platforms, MRO vendors, satellite connectivity providers, identity providers, reservation systems, engineering PLM, and managed service providers can all become operational chokepoints.

12. Recommended Actions

Priority	Owner	Action
High	SOC	Deploy hunts in this report and tune to local telemetry.
High	IT/security engineering	Patch exposed systems, verify EDR

		coverage, and restrict script interpreters where possible.
Medium	Identity team	Review new privileged accounts, OAuth grants, and risky sign-ins for the lookback period.
Medium	Threat intel	Track source updates for IOCs, exploit details, and sector-specific victimology.

13. References

- [1] Unit 42 Screening Serpens 2026 espionage campaigns — <https://unit42.paloaltonetworks.com/tracking-iran-apt-screening-serpens/>
- [2] CISA Iran cyber threat resources — <https://www.cisa.gov/topics/cyber-threats-and-advisories/advanced-persistent-threats/iran>
- [3] MITRE ATT&CK Phishing Spearphishing Attachment — <https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1566/001/>